

dor. Not only will she be used for advertising but also for store appearances as more stores open in India. "I have always admired and been fascinated by Bvlgari's magnificent works of art... From the rare colourful gemstones used in Bvlgari's timeless jewellery creations to the scented flowers which become the main ingredients of its luxurious fragrances, we connect so organically over our love for India and the beauty it has to offer," Chopra Jonas said in a statement.

Bvlgari's love affair with India truly started in last year's wedding season when it launched its version of the traditional mangalsutra—a piece of jewellery worn by married Hindu women from different communities. Set in 18-carat yellow gold, the Bvlgari Mangalsutra features five circles—reminiscent of the brand's signature circular motif—studded with pavé diamonds and round black onyx inserts, whose inclusion is integral to the traditional design. Priced at ₹3.82 lakh, the Bvlgari Mangalsutra has been a success with a three-month waiting period.

"In India, western jewellery has not been as successful as in other countries probably because Indian culture is so deep-rooted that luxury brands have to adapt somehow to some local traditions," explains Babin. He says going ahead, 10 per cent of its jewellery will be India-inspired and the remaining will be part of its global assortment. "The Mangalsutra is the first step into that Indianisation of Bvlgari, working with Priyanka to combine the Bvlgari Bvlgari icon [name of a collection from Bvlgari] together with the mangalsutra spirit, to create the first 'branded' mangalsutra, at least from a western luxury brand," says Babin. Chopra Jonas has been credited with being a collaborator in conceiving the design.

"Conceptualising and selling



'WE NEED TO INTEGRATE LOCAL CREATIVITY'

Taking inspiration from the country's culture and tradition, **Jean-Christophe Babin**, Group CEO, Bvlgari, hopes to create products that resonate with Indians

BY SMITA TRIPATHI

FRENCH BY BIRTH and Italian at heart, Jean-Christophe Babin, 63, is the Group CEO of Italian luxury house Bvlgari, in which French luxury conglomerate LVMH Moët Hennessy Louis Vuitton acquired a controlling stake in 2011. The brand, though primarily known for jewellery, has diversified into watches, fragrances, leather goods and hospitality. In an exclusive conversation with *Business Today*, Babin speaks about Bvlgari's plans for India, working with Priyanka Chopra Jonas, and its focus on watches and e-commerce. Edited excerpts:

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How popular has the Bvlgari Mangalsutra been in India?

It's been very successful commercially, of course, but also in terms of image. I think the Indian clients have very much appreciated that a brand like Bvlgari would pay tribute and respect to your culture.

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Will we see more India-specific creations in the future?

If we want to be successful in India the way we have been successful in many countries, we probably need to integrate more creativity specific to the country. When we went to China, we added jade in our precious stones, which we didn't use in the rest of the world. It helped to resonate with the Chinese for whom jade is very important. In the US, we introduced a lot of yellow gold while our offerings are traditionally in rose gold. We are an Italian firm, so we'll never have an Indian assortment only, but we will have a twist of Indian tradition in our Italian assortment, a twist of US preferences, and a twist of Chinese preferences in our gemstones assortment.

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How has it been working with Priyanka Chopra Jonas?

I know Priyanka for a long time. I partnered with her in